

Introduction

I wrote this book with the purpose of sharing useful experiences and insights, grounded in the teachings of Jesus, as well as in the writings and scholarship of Doctors of the Catholic Church. It does not matter whether you are Catholic, because many people who are not Catholic nevertheless respect the work and scholarship of Doctors of the Church such as Saint Thomas Aquinas and Saint Augustine.

Today, there are *coaches* for virtually everything on the internet: *faith coaches*, nutrition coaches, relationship coaches, weight-loss coaches, and, in short, coaches for almost anything one can imagine. Yet many of them have distorted concepts and information in order to influence their thousands of followers, gain “likes,” and ultimately sell e-books, video courses, training programs, and other products, thereby making money and gaining fame.

They tell people what they want to hear, distorting reality and leading their followers to perceive their fallacies as absolute truths.

Social media can be extremely useful in many areas of knowledge and can be excellent learning tools. Yet in many cases, they have also become something of a jungle, where ravenous wolves stalk their prey in order to spread teachings that blend Christianity with nutrition, spirituality with wealth, and religion with all manner of unrelated subjects. In an effort to attract followers, some people try to bring Jesus—or concepts related to spirituality—into virtually every subject imaginable.

It is common to find stories on social media about relationships that have ended because one of the people involved followed the advice of an “influencer” who taught that, in a romantic relationship, both partners must be happy twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week; otherwise, the person is supposedly in a toxic relationship.

Others claim that if parents did not give their children a perfect childhood, like the ones portrayed in Hollywood movies, or if they ever behaved imperfectly, then they are toxic parents.

Some financial *coaches*, meanwhile, start from the premise that if you are not rich or a millionaire, you are not following Jesus correctly. According to this way of thinking, you would be committing terrible sins, because they equate every form of material wealth—regardless of the means by which it was acquired—with blessings from Heaven. Consequently, any life that does not involve wealth, luxury, and ostentation supposedly makes a person a failure.

They therefore preach a perfection that has never existed and never will in human history, leaving people frustrated because they cannot attain a supposedly perfect life in every respect.

These are precisely the issues this book seeks to explore. Not with the intention of presenting perfect human beings, perfect families, perfect relationships, or a life free from difficulties, but rather of showing that human reality is far more complex than the simplistic narratives we encounter every day on social media.

The Christian life, like human existence itself, is not a promise of a life without difficulties. Rather, it is a journey in which we learn to face our limitations, acknowledge our mistakes, forgive, mature, and understand that not every form of suffering is the result of someone having wronged us.

Throughout these pages, I will seek to examine these questions in light of the teachings of Jesus and the reflections of great thinkers in the Christian tradition, while never losing sight of the difficulties and contradictions of real life.